Evaluating Team Strength Using a Composite Power Score: A 2026 World Cup Analysis

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Introduction

Historically, FIFA World Cup tournaments have been controlled by a subset of elite footballing nations, with teams such as Brazil, Germany, Italy, Argentina, and France retaining the vast majority of titles. These nations typically enter tournaments with high FIFA rankings and fan anticipation due to their consistent excellence, reinforcing the notion that success is closely linked to sustained dominance.

Despite this, recent World Cups often feature many surprises, such as the reigning champions falling well below expectations for the next World Cup, known as the "Champions Curse". Such instances have occurred with powerhouses including Italy, Germany and Spain, all eliminated in the first round of the World Cup after winning the previous tournament.

Moreover, recent editions of the World Cup included "Dark Horse" contenders—nations that surpass expectations and deliver results beyond what international rankings or history would predict. Notable examples include Costa Rica's surge to the quarter-final in 2014, Croatia's dramatic run to the final in 2018, and Morocco's semi-final breakthrough in 2022, suggesting that recent form and momentum can significantly influence tournament outcomes.

While FIFA rankings provide a general measure of team strength, they do not fully capture all metrics of team performance and improvements. As a result, an overreliance on FIFA rankings and historical performance may overlook teams that are currently performing at a higher level than expected.

The objective of this project is to develop a data-driven model to evaluate and rank the 48 national football teams participating in the 2026 FIFA World Cup. The model utilizes multiple performance-related metrics into a single "power score" that reflects a combination of current form, recent national success and overall historical strength. Additionally, the project is used to identify "dark horse" teams. These are teams that may outperform expectations, in contrast to the current FIFA rankings and expectations from fans.

Data Set

The raw dataset featured the last 10 match results for every international footballing nation, including goals scored, goals conceded, and match outcomes. This data was initially filtered to include the 48 qualified national teams relevant to the 2026 World Cup.

Data cleaning and preprocessing steps were applied to ensure consistency and usability. Match results were converted into a standardized “win-draw-loss” metric system, currently used in professional football. This process utilizes a 3–1–0 points system based on goals scored and conceded, which will be further analyzed.

The data was then aggregated to create team-level performance metrics for each nation, calculating key statistics such as “Average goals scored”, “Average goals conceded”, “Average goal difference” and “points per game”. These metrics are clear indicators of team performance. For instance, a country’s average goals scored statistic demonstrates how dangerous their attacking players may be. Average goals conceded provides an accurate defensive structure and goalkeeping capability. Points per game will measure a team's consistency, and the average goal difference will provide insight into how dominant teams win or lose games.

Additional features were incorporated from external sources, such as the most recent FIFA rankings, World Cup appearances and medals, and continental titles won in the last decade.

Methodology: Power Score

To measure each participating nation's overall strength, we create a “Power Score.” This custom scale utilizes 6 weighted components regarding each nation, indicating their competitive aptitude.

The Power Score is the sum of the following components:

- $0.10 \times$ Goal Difference
- $0.35 \times$ (Points Per Game $\div$ 3)
- $0.35 \times ((100 - \text{FIFA Rank}) \div 100)^2$
- $0.05 \times$ World Cup Medals
- $0.05 \times$ World Cup Appearances
- $0.10 \times$ Continental Titles (last 10 years)

Key scaling decisions:

- Normalization: Points per game were divided by 3 to scale values between 0 and 1
- Nonlinear scaling: FIFA ranking is squared to emphasize the difference in strength between highly ranked teams.

One key factor in the model is how the weighting choices affect the results. The power score assigns 70% of its weight to points per game and FIFA ranking, meaning recent performance and ranking have the most significant influence on how teams are rated. This approach highlights teams in good form or have high rankings, but it can also introduce bias by favouring teams that have consistently been strong. Teams with a history of high rankings are likely to maintain high scores, even if their recent results are only slightly better than those of their competitors.

On the other hand, teams that are performing well now but have weaker rankings or less history may not get enough credit. Because of this, the model tends to favour established teams, which is why there are not many dark horse candidates. Changing the weights or giving more importance to recent performance could lead to more varied results and bring more underdog teams into the spotlight.

Teams were then classified into their respective tiers, based on their power score:

- Favourite (≥ 2.0)
- Contender (≥ 1.4)
- Dark Horse (≥ 0.8)
- Unlikely (≥ 0.4)
- Highly Improbable (< 0.4)

Results:

The power scores ranged from approximately 0.19 to 2.35, indicating a wide variation in team strength across the dataset. A clear separation is observed between elite nations and the rest, with a small group exceeding a score of 2.0 and forming the “Favourite” category. The majority of these teams fell within a range of 0.8 and 1.6, showcasing a competitive middle tier.

The highest-ranked teams in the model include traditional football powerhouses such as Brazil, Germany and Argentina. Due to their excellent historical victories, high FIFA ranking, and strong current form, they achieved a power score higher than all other competitors.

Teams classified as contenders exhibit proficient recent performance and international success, but lack the same level of historical achievement or ranking advantage as the tournament favourites with this metric.

The data identified a multitude of teams that can be classified as strong dark horse candidates. Although certain teams display high values in recent performance metrics, including points per game and goal difference, these strengths are offset by weaker historical performance or lower FIFA ranking. The majority of the dark horses remain to succeed on the international stage, and their power score reflects great form, but a lack of dominance.

Visualization:

The results were visualized using Power BI through two key charts:

- Power Score Ranking (Bar Chart): Teams were ranked in descending order to showcase the power score. This provided a clear comparison of overall strength and allowed for simple recognition of top contenders.
- Power Score vs FIFA Ranking (Scatter Plot): A scatter plot was used to analyze the relationship between FIFA hierarchy and the calculated power score. A trend line was included to identify deviations from expected performance.

Analysis:

The visual analysis clarifies the relationship between team strength and performance across the dataset. The scatter plot linking power score and FIFA ranking shows a pronounced inverse correlation, indicating that teams with higher FIFA rankings typically record better power scores. This demonstrates that FIFA ranking remains a strong measure of overall team strength, even when considered alongside recent form and historical results.

While the trend line illustrates minor deviations from expected performance, these differences remain limited. Teams plotted above the trend line surpass expectations relative to their ranking, while those below the trend line are underachieving. However, these deviations are insufficient to disrupt the competitive hierarchy, as most teams closely coincide with their projected positions.

Notably, several nations classified as dark horses, such as Japan, Morocco, and Croatia, fall well below the trend line, indicating that although these teams achieve relatively strong power scores, they are not outperforming expectations relative to their FIFA standing. Instead, their performance is slightly weaker than what their ranking would suggest. Compared to the top-tier nations, these dark horses do not carry the same footballing dynasty. While these teams demonstrate strong recent form with high points per game and goal difference, they have not shown a similar level of success in international tournaments, and the bulk of their accomplishments are much more recent than traditionally dominant teams.

Additionally, the high weighting assigned to FIFA ranking increases expectations for these teams, meaning nations that do not perform exceptionally across all metrics are deemed to be slightly underperforming relative to their ranking. This highlights an important distinction within the model: teams can be categorized as dark horses based on balanced and competitive metrics without necessarily exceeding expected performance levels. Consequently, the results suggest that even among dark horse teams, there is limited evidence of significant overperformance, reinforcing the stability of the overall ranking structure.

Moreover, the bar chart ranks teams by power score and clearly separates top-tier teams from the rest. A small group of teams occupies the largest range of scores, while the majority cluster within the middle range. This distribution reinforces the idea that elite teams maintain a consistent advantage across multiple metrics, including recent performance, ranking, and historical success.

Overall, the analysis suggests that team performance predominantly aligned with existing rankings and that the competitive landscape remains concentrated among top-tier nations. The model indicates that tournament outcomes are likely to be dominated by established teams, with relatively limited potential for lower-ranked teams to emerge as true underdogs.

Limitations:

While the model provides useful insights into team strength, several limitations should be considered when interpreting the results.

- The model uses data from each team's last 10 matches. This approach highlights recent form but may miss longer-term trends or differences in opponents' strength. A team's results might also be affected by how tough their recent matches were, which the model does not directly adjust for.
- The calculation of the power score is based on subjective choices. Greater weight was given to performance metrics to emphasize current form, but this may introduce bias by favouring teams that are already ranked higher.
- Important external variables, such as player injuries and suspensions, squad selection, tactical changes, and related conditions, are not weighted. These factors can significantly impact performance in a tournament setting but are difficult to quantify within the scope of this analysis.
- The use of historical metrics such as World Cup medals and appearances may disproportionately benefit traditionally strong teams. While these variables provide valuable context, they may reduce the model's sensitivity to recent improvements in less historically successful nations.

Conclusion:

This project created a data-driven ranking model to assess national team strength for the 2026 FIFA World Cup. By combining recent performance, FIFA rankings, and historical success, the model provides a clear and consistent ranking that closely aligns with what is generally expected of team quality.

The analysis reveals a strong correlation between FIFA ranking and team performance, suggesting that global rankings are a reliable gauge of team strength. Teams like Japan, Morocco, and Croatia are viewed as dark horses because of their recent strong form, but they perform just below what their rankings suggest. This means these teams are solid and balanced, but not greatly surpassing expectations.

The results indicate that established teams are likely to dominate knockout competition, offering limited opportunity for lower-ranked nations to emerge. This underscores the value of integrating various performance metrics when assessing team strength, further showcasing the consistency of the existing competitive environment.

Future improvements, including adjustments to the weighting scheme and the incorporation of additional external factors, may enhance the model's ability to capture rising teams and identify potential deviations from expected outcomes.